

Root cause analysis (RCA)



Incident Description	Unable to access the QuickBooks company file	Affected Users	Multiple concurrent QuickBooks users
Date and Time of Incident	12 JAN 2026: 08 : 45 PM	Prepared Date	16 JAN 2026
Environment	Windows RDS + SMB File Server	Prepared By	Geo Thomas
Incident Status	Closed	Incident closed Date	14 JAN 2026

1. Incident Summary

Multiple users were unable to access the QuickBooks company file operating in multi-user mode. Errors indicated communication failures and invalid parameters, preventing normal business operations. The issue required administrative intervention to restore service.

2. Impact Assessment

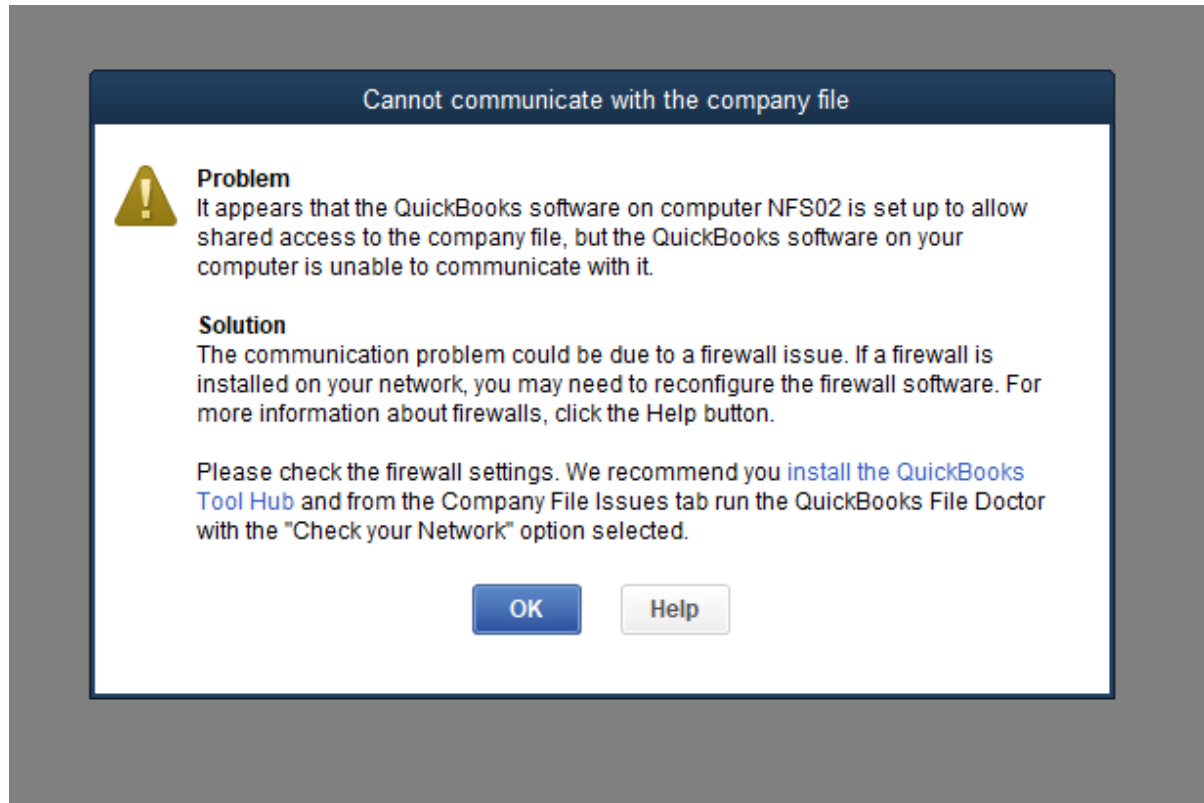
The incident had a medium to high impact, as the accounting service was partially unavailable and directly affected critical financial operations. The urgency of the issue required timely resolution, while still allowing for structured troubleshooting due to the absence of a safe workaround. Although core functions were not completely halted, multiple concurrent QuickBooks users were unable to access the shared company file simultaneously, resulting in transaction processing delays and temporary operational disruption. Given the organization's high dependency on QuickBooks during business hours, the incident posed a tangible risk to financial reporting and day-to-day accounting activities if not resolved promptly.

3. Reason for Major Incident (P2) Declaration

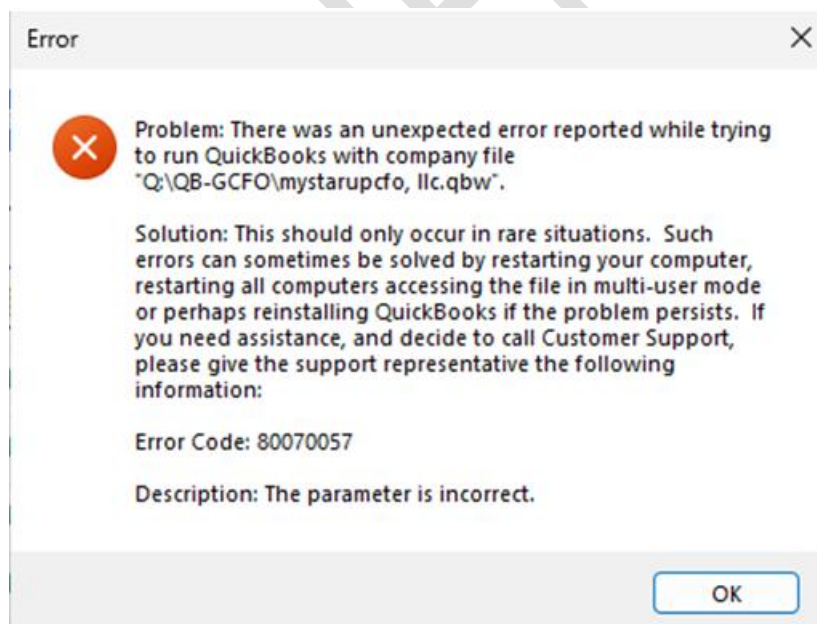
The incident was escalated to a P2 Major Incident because multiple users reported the issue from different time zones, indicating a widespread and systemic problem rather than an isolated user-specific issue. The incident affected a core finance application critical to business operations, with no immediate or safe workaround available. Any attempt to force access carried a potential risk of data corruption to the QuickBooks company file. Additionally, resolution required dependency on QuickBooks OEM support for application-level validation and confirmation of a safe remediation approach, further justifying the Major Incident classification.

4. Symptoms Observed

- “Cannot communicate with the company file”



- Error Code **80070057** – The parameter is incorrect



- File reported as “already in use”

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- Issue persisted until file locks were manually cleared

5. Incident Timeline & Chronology

Event	Date & Time
First user-reported issue	12 Jan 2026 – ~04:19 PM
Multiple similar tickets received	12–13 Jan 2026
Incident escalated to P2	12 Jan 2026 – Evening
OEM dependency engaged (QuickBooks Support)	13 Jan 2026
Root cause identified	13 Jan 2026 – 11:48 PM
Corrective action implemented	13 Jan 2026
Service fully restored	13 Jan 2026 – 11:53 PM
Incident closed	14 Jan 2026
RCA prepared	16 Jan 2026

6. Impact Assessment

Total impacted users: 13

Ticket	User	Issue Summary	Date
183566	Jithin Thomas	Unable to open company file	12 Jan 2026
184273	Akshay Pai	Unable to open client file	13 Jan 2026
184228	Deepak	Unable to open client file	13 Jan 2026
184314	Sowmya	Unable to open client file	13 Jan 2026
184115	Ayush Malviya	QBD error on Numera Cloud	12 Jan 2026
184119	Nandini Parmar	Communication error	12 Jan 2026
184127	Paramesh M	Cannot communicate with company file	13 Jan 2026
184144	Neha Kaushik	Urgent – QBD not working	13 Jan 2026
184145	Nisha Chauhan	QBD issue	12 Jan 2026
184146	Surendra Agarwal	QBD not working	12 Jan 2026
184129	Sneha Poojary	Login error	13 Jan 2026
184136	Goutham	QBD issue	12 Jan 2026
184130	Karan Kumar	Login issue	12 Jan 2026

7. Data collection

The following data points were collected during troubleshooting:

- Firewall was disabled
- Server was domain-joined

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- Users could access the UNC path
 - All QuickBooks services were running
 - Resource Monitor showed file handle locks
 - Error screenshots from QuickBooks and Windows
 - Process-level file locking analysis
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8. Identify Possible Causes:

Initial suspected causes included:

- Network or firewall restrictions
- Group Policy or OS-level restrictions
- Antivirus/EDR interference
- QuickBooks service malfunction
- File permission issues

After analysis, it was confirmed that the QuickBooks DB service was holding an exclusive lock on the company file, preventing new user sessions.

9. Root Cause Statement

What Failed

The QuickBooks company file was locked by orphaned QuickBooks sessions, preventing new users from accessing the file in multi-user mode.

Why OEM Dependency Was Required

While file locks were visible at the OS level, confirmation was required from QuickBooks OEM support to validate:

- QuickBooks Database Engine locking behaviour
- Application-level handling of disconnected RDP sessions
- Safe remediation steps without risking data integrity

Root Cause (Confirmed with OEM)

Users disconnected RDP sessions without properly closing QuickBooks. This caused the QuickBooks Database Engine to retain exclusive SMB file locks, blocking subsequent access attempts.

10. Why This Happened Now (Trigger Analysis)

Although the environment had been operational for over two months, the incident was triggered by cumulative risk factors, not a sudden change.

Triggering Conditions

1. Increased Concurrent Usage
 - Higher simultaneous QuickBooks sessions increased lock contention risk
2. Accumulation of Orphaned Sessions
 - No automatic cleanup of disconnected RDP sessions
 - Locks accumulated silently over time
3. Absence of Safeguards
 - No RDP session timeout enforcement
 - No monitoring for long-running QuickBooks processes
 - No alerting on persistent file locks

11. 5-Why Analysis

Problem: Users could not access the QuickBooks company file.

1. **Why?**
The company file was locked and reported as in use.
2. **Why?**
Active file handles were still open against the company file.
3. **Why?**
QuickBooks processes were still running in disconnected RDP sessions.
4. **Why?**
Users closed RDP windows instead of exiting QuickBooks and logging off.
5. **Why?**
There were no enforced RDP session policies, automated cleanup, or user awareness controls.

Root Cause

Lack of session governance and process enforcement resulted in orphaned QuickBooks sessions and

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persistent file locks.

12. Environmental Change Review

Area	Change
Network	No
Firewall	No
OS / Patch	No
QuickBooks version	No
Access / Permissions	No

13. Contributing Factors

The issue was influenced by several contributing factors. The file-based architecture of the QuickBooks application relies heavily on network file locks, making it sensitive to improper session termination. The system was configured in multi-user mode without adequate session enforcement, allowing multiple users to access the same company file without strict control over session cleanup. A significant process gap existed due to the absence of an RDP disconnected-session timeout, which allowed user sessions to remain active even after disconnection. Additionally, the human factor played a role, as users exited by closing their RDP sessions instead of properly closing the QuickBooks application and logging off. Finally, a monitoring gap was identified, as there were no mechanisms in place to detect or alert on orphaned file locks, allowing the issue to persist until manual intervention was performed.

14. Resolution Summary (Incident Management)

- Identified stale SMB file handles on NFS02
 - Terminated orphaned QuickBooks processes
 - Released locks on .qbw, .nd, .lck files
 - Verified file integrity
 - Restored multi-user access
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15. Corrective & Preventive Actions

Preventive measures have been identified to reduce the risk of recurrence and strengthen operational stability. These include implementing RDP session governance by enforcing disconnected session

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timeouts and forced logoff policies to prevent orphaned sessions. Operational controls will be reinforced through a standard operating procedure (SOP) that mandates proper exit from the QuickBooks application before logging off, supported by targeted user awareness communications. In addition, monitoring and automation will be introduced to enable scheduled detection of orphaned QuickBooks Desktop processes and alerting on prolonged file locks. As directed by the QuickBooks OEM, users experiencing application-related issues will be required to run diagnostics using QuickBooks Tool Hub to identify and remediate company file or network-related issues before escalation. Finally, an OEM-aligned configuration review will be conducted periodically in collaboration with QuickBooks support to ensure the environment remains aligned with vendor-recommended best practices.

16. Lessons Learned

The incident highlighted several key lessons learned. File-based applications tend to degrade gradually rather than fail instantly, allowing underlying risks to accumulate unnoticed over time. Remote Desktop Services (RDS) environments require stricter session discipline and governance to prevent orphaned processes from impacting shared resources. Dependencies on OEM support must be factored into incident timelines, as application-level validation can influence both diagnosis and resolution duration. The absence of proactive monitoring enables silent risk accumulation, making issues visible only when user impact occurs. Overall, the incident reinforced that well-defined preventive controls are essential to ensure stability and resilience as the environment scales.

***** End of the Document *****